

I hate Web sites that...

We asked people in Digit what they hated most about some Web sites. This is a list of definite no-no's when designing your Web site.

"...have Flash interfaces. When I see a flash site loading, quick as a flash, I click on the little X on the top right."
Ahmed Shaikh, Senior Writer

"...have ads that come in from a slow server, so the entire page gets held up just for an ad or two."
Ram Mohan Rao, Copy Editor

"...are badly designed, are difficult to navigate, or ones that sport loud, garish colours"
Meera Vankipuram, Writer

"...have a million pop ups, pop downs, pop unders, pop anything. Pop ups make me pop my cork!"
Garfield D'Souza, Copy Editor

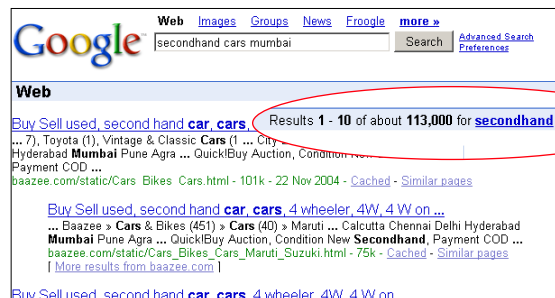
background, use the same background for all pages—this will ensure that the background image needs to be downloaded only once. Avoid animated images like the plague, because if you go too far, you might end up with a site like www.seizurer-obots.com, and no one wants to see that sort of thing.

Once you have created your Web site, you should check and re-check all links, spellings and images thoroughly. Nothing makes a site look more unprofessional than a link that leads nowhere, images that don't load, or spelling mistakes in the text.

Searching For Salvation

There are millions of Web sites out there which could be useful to us, but just haven't been discovered by search engines yet. The problem with most of these sites is that they are not designed with search engines in mind.

These sites fall into a category called the "Deep Web," and if you are setting up a business site,



If, for example, you are a second-hand car dealer in Mumbai, your Web site is competing with 1,13,000 other pages. So start optimising that site now!

this is one category you want to steer clear of.

The biggest mistake people make when checking their rankings on a search engine is searching for the domain name. For example, if you go to Google and search for "thinkdigit" or "thinkdigit.com", the first search result is www.thinkdigit.com. This is pretty much akin to walking into your home and asking your mother where you live!

By entering your domain name in the search field, you are giving the search engine no other option but to find you. We don't want a search engine to find us in a group of one; we want it to pick us out from billions of other pages.

As an exercise, enter, into Google, the product or service that your company provides. Let's say you manufacture and sell painted pottery. A search for "painted pottery" in Google throws up more than 12 lakh results.

Let's say your site manages to get listed somewhere in the middle of all these pages—a potential customer would have to search through 60,000 pages of results in order to find you.

Interestingly, you should also know that an estimated 90 per cent of Internet searches end on the first search result page—either the searcher finds what he is looking for, or he refines or changes his search.

Admittedly, our example search term, "painted pottery," seems a little too generic. Let's try "poetry painted on pottery in Patna"! Now this search term sounds like a tongue twister, and will probably throw up nothing, right? Wrong! As this article was being written, Google threw up 57 results, and the first 10 results are from 10 different sites—there could be more, but a searcher never goes past the first results page, remember?

Now imagine you are a second-hand car dealer in Mumbai! What chance do you have against the thousands of pages that search engines will throw at surfers when they search for "second-hand cars in Mumbai"?

What's In A Name?

The most basic way to optimise your site is to make proper use of HTML tags. In order to view a page's HTML source in

Frontpage, all you need to do is look for a little tab called "HTML" at the bottom left of the page that you are editing. In order for your site to ascend in the search rankings, all your tags need to work together and contain the same keywords. Choose your keywords very, very carefully.

Think about your company, what products you offer, and what the most basic and generic description you can come up with is. What you sell and where you are located is a good bet. So, "second-hand cars Mumbai" for a Mumbai-based dealer who buys and sells used cars would be the ideal set of keywords.

The first tag you need to edit is the "Title" tag. This is the tag that search engine spiders read first: it is the description that will show up on the top left of a browser's window, and also the text that search engines will display when they come across your site. Needless to say, this is the most important tag of all!

Whether or not you get a visitor to click on your site depends almost entirely on this title for each page. Think of it as a really, really short description of your company. Most search engines will display only a part of a long title tag, so make sure to keep it below 65 characters.

As a hypothetical test, let's imagine that you are from Mumbai, and want to buy a second-hand car. You are Net savvy, and obviously hit the search engines immediately. You search for "Second-hand cars Mumbai". The search engine throws up the following results:

"Welcome to Yoursite.com.

"Yoursite.com. Unbelievably priced second-hand cars"

"Second-hand cars in Mumbai; 15 years; 10 lakh satisfied customers"

Hosting Options

If you have purchased hosting, it's a good idea to know whether your server supports Frontpage extensions. If it does not, you are likely to get a feedback and search section that does not work. If you are using the free options, such as Geocities.com or Freewebs.com, you cannot use Frontpage extensions. You can always add a Google search to your Web site later—you will need Google, Yahoo!, etc., to index your site first.